

Area of Study 2B – Christianity

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Christianity as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world, and its beliefs and teachings on life, specifically about the issues of peace and conflict, and crime and punishment.

There are four sections: Christian Beliefs, Crime and Punishment, Living the Christian Life and Peace and Conflict.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Christians today should be explored throughout the sections. This should include reference to how the Bible informs a Christian's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Christianity within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should recognise that Christianity is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Judaism, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast two areas of belief and practice within Christianity with one of either Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Judaism, or Sikhism:

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.6)*
- The practice and significance of worship (3.1)*

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Christianity with non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Christianity there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Christianity in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Catholic, Orthodox, Protestant and other Christian traditions.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The Trinity: the nature and significance of the Trinity as expressed in the Nicene Creed; the nature and significance of the oneness of God; the nature and significance of each of the Persons individually, including reference to Matthew 3:13–17; how this is reflected in Christian worship and belief today.
1.2	The creation of the universe and of humanity: the biblical account of creation and divergent ways in which it may be understood by Christians, including as literal and metaphorical; the role of the Word and Spirit in creation, including John 1:1–18 and Genesis 1–3; the importance of creation for Christians today.
1.3	The Incarnation: the nature and importance of the person of Jesus Christ as the incarnate Son of God; the biblical basis of this teaching, including John 1.1–18 and 1 Timothy 3:16 and its significance for Christians today.
1.4	The last days of Jesus' life: the Last Supper, betrayal, arrest, trial, crucifixion, resurrection and ascension of Jesus; the accounts of these within the Bible, including Luke 22–24 and the significance of these events to understanding the person of Jesus Christ.
1.5	The nature and significance of salvation and the role of Christ within salvation: law, sin, grace and Spirit, the role of Christ in salvation, including John 3:10–21 and Acts 4:8–12; the nature and significance of atonement within Christianity and its link to salvation.
1.6*	Christian eschatology: divergent Christian teachings about life after death, including the nature and significance of resurrection, judgement, heaven, and hell and purgatory with reference to the 39 Articles of Religion and Catholic teachings; how beliefs about life after death are shown in the Bible, including reference to 2 Corinthians 5:1–10 and divergent understandings as to why they are important for Christians today.
1.7	The problem of evil/suffering and a loving and righteous God: the problems it raises for Christians about the nature of God including reference to omnipotence and benevolence, including Psalm 103; how the problem may cause believers to question their faith or the existence of God; the nature and examples of natural suffering, moral suffering.
1.8	Divergent solutions offered to the problem of evil/suffering and a loving and righteous God: biblical, theoretical and practical, including reference to Psalm 119, Job, free will, vale of soul-making, prayer, and charity; the success of solutions to the problem.

Students should have an understanding of:

2.1	Christian attitudes towards justice: the nature of justice and why justice is important for Christians, including Micah 3 and 6; Christian responses to why justice is important for victims; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) about why justice is important, regardless of religion and belief, and Christian responses to these attitudes.
2.2	Christian attitudes towards crime: Christian teachings about and responses to the nature, causes and problem of crime, including John 8:1–11; what action is taken by Christian individuals and Christian groups to end crime, including Prison Fellowship and Street Pastors.
2.3	Christian teachings about good, evil and suffering: Christian teachings about the nature of good actions and how they are rewarded, and teachings about the nature of evil actions; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) about why people suffer, including believing in religion, and Christian responses to them; divergent Christian teachings about why people suffer, including the Parable of the Sheep and Goats (Matthew 25:31–46).
2.4	Christian attitudes towards punishment: the nature of punishment; divergent Christian attitudes towards the use of punishment, the nature and meaning of biblical teachings about punishment, including Luke 12:35–48; Christian teachings on why punishment can be regarded as justice and why punishment might be needed in society.
2.5	Christian attitudes towards the aims of punishment: Christian attitudes towards each of the aims of punishment (protection, retribution, deterrence and reformation); the nature and meaning of biblical examples of teaching about punishment, including Galatians 6:1–10.
2.6	Christian teachings about forgiveness: Christian teachings and responses to the nature of forgiveness and biblical teachings about it; how offenders are forgiven by the community and why this is needed; Christian teachings about the nature of restorative justice, examples of its use by Christian organisations and why is it important for criminals, including Matthew 5:21–26.
2.7	Christian teachings about the treatment of criminals: biblical teachings about the treatment of criminals, including Proverbs 31:8–9; divergent Christian attitudes towards the use of torture, human rights, fair trial and trial by jury; the application of ethical theories, such as situation ethics, which may accept the use of torture if it is for the greater good.
2.8	Christian attitudes towards the death penalty: the nature and purpose of capital punishment; divergent Christian teachings about capital punishment, including interpretations of Genesis 9:6, Exodus 21:8–13 and Matthew 5:38–48; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) attitudes towards the use of capital punishment, including the application of ethical theories, such as situation ethics, and Christian responses to them.

Students should have an understanding of:

3.1	Christian worship: liturgical and non-liturgical forms of worship, including activities which are informal and individual, with reference to the <i>Book of Common Prayer</i> ; when each form might be used and why; divergent Christian attitudes towards the practices, meaning and significance of liturgical and non-liturgical forms of worship in Christian life today, with reference to denominations which worship with less structure such as some Pentecostal churches.
3.2	The role of the sacraments in Christian life and their practice in two denominations: the role of the sacraments/ordinance as a whole; the nature and importance of the meaning and celebration of baptism and the Eucharist in at least two denominations, including reference to the 39 Articles XXV–XXXVI; divergent Christian attitudes towards the use and number of sacraments in Orthodox, Catholic and Protestant traditions.
3.3	The nature and purpose of prayer: the nature of and examples of the different types of prayer; set prayers; informal prayer and the Lord's Prayer, including Matthew 6:5–14; when each type might be used and why; divergent Christian attitudes towards the importance of each type of prayer for Christians today.
3.4	Pilgrimage: the nature, history and purpose of pilgrimage, including interpretations of Luke 2:41–43; the significance of the places people go on pilgrimage; divergent Christian teachings about whether pilgrimage is important for Christians today, with specific reference to Catholic and Protestant understandings; the activities associated with, and significance of, Jerusalem, Iona, Taizé and Walsingham.
3.5	Christian religious celebrations: the nature and history of Christian festivals in the church year, including Christmas and Easter; the significance of celebrating Advent and Christmas; the significance of celebrating Holy Week and Easter, with reference to interpretations of 1 Corinthians 15:12–34.
3.6	The future of the Christian Church: Church growth, the history and purpose of missionary and evangelical work, including reference to Mark 16:9–20 and John 20:21–22; divergent ways this is put into practice by the Church locally, nationally and globally; Christian attitudes of why evangelical work is important for the Church and for individual Christians.
3.7	The role and importance of the local church in the local community: how and why it helps the individual believer and the local area; local parish activities, including interpretations of 1 Peter 5:1–4, ecumenism, outreach work, the centre of Christian identity and worship through living practices.
3.8	The role and importance of the Church in the worldwide community: how and why it works for reconciliation and the problems faced by the persecuted Church; divergent Christian responses to teachings about charity, including 1 Corinthians 13 and Matthew 25:31–46; the work of Christian Aid, what it does and why.

Students should have an understanding of:

4.1	Christian attitudes towards peace: divergent Christian attitudes towards the nature and importance of peace for Christians; Church teachings about peace; Jesus as a peacemaker, including interpretations of Luke 22:47–53.
4.2	The role of Christians in peacemaking: Christian teachings about peacemaking; the importance of justice, forgiveness and reconciliation for Christians in peacemaking; the work of one Christian group working for peace today, what it does and why it tries to work for peace, including Matthew 5:1–16.
4.3	Christian attitudes to conflict: Christian teachings and responses to the nature and causes of conflict; Christian responses to the problems conflict causes, including Matthew 26:47–56 and links to situation ethics; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) attitudes about the role of religion in the causes of conflict and Christian responses to them.
4.4	Christian attitudes to pacifism: divergent Christian teachings and responses to the nature and history of pacifism, including reference to Quakers; divergent Christian teachings about passive resistance, including John 14:22–31 and an example of its use, including Martin Luther King.
4.5	Christian attitudes to the Just War theory: Christian teachings and responses to the nature, history and importance of the Just War theory; the conditions of a Just War; divergent Christian opinions about whether a Just War is possible, including Romans 13:1–7; the application of ethical theories such as situation ethics.
4.6	Christian attitudes to Holy War: Christian teachings and responses to the nature of a Holy War; the nature and meaning of teachings about war and peace as shown in the Bible, including Matthew 10:34–40; divergent Christian teachings about war; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) attitudes towards Holy War and Christian responses to them.
4.7	Christian attitudes to weapons of mass destruction (WMD): Christian teachings and responses to the problems and benefits of WMD; Christian attitudes towards the use of such weapons, including interpretations of Deuteronomy 20; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) and the application of ethical theories (such as utilitarianism) which support the acquisition of weapons of mass destruction, and Christian responses to them.
4.8	Christian attitudes to issues surrounding conflict: Christian teachings and responses to the nature and history of problems involved in conflict – violence, war and terrorism, including Luke 6:27–31; how Christians have worked to overcome these issues; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) views towards the issues surrounding conflict and Christian responses to them.